



PRACTICAL GUIDE

CLAUDE COWORK



How to set up Claude so it actually does the work for you, instead of handing back polished text that misses the point.

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SECTION 01

Less chatbot, more coworker

Most people think Claude works like ChatGPT: a text box, you type, it answers. That's claude.ai, the browser version. Cowork works differently.

Cowork lives right on your computer. It reads and writes files in real folders, builds Word documents, creates spreadsheets with working formulas, and installs plugins for your profession. And when it's missing data, it asks, instead of guessing and handing back pretty garbage.

Essentially it's the power of Claude Code (the agentic tool for developers), reworked for everyone else. No terminal, no command line, no code. Just describe the result, show it your files, and get on with your day while it works.

RULE OF THUMB
Need a quick answer or a brainstorm, go to Chat. Need a result as a file (analysis, spreadsheet, presentation, report), go to Cowork. If the output should be a document, that's Cowork.

Three modes of Claude for different jobs

	CHAT	COWORK	PROJECTS
What it is	Text box: you type, it answers	Agent on your computer: reads files, makes documents	Workspace with memory and files
Access	Web, desktop, mobile	Desktop only	Web, desktop, mobile
Files	Via download	Straight into your folder	Via download
Plugins	No	Yes, slash commands	No
Connectors	Yes	Yes	Yes
Memory	None between sessions	Through files and instructions	Yes, within the project

Same Claude, three ways to work with it. Only Cowork touches your files directly.

SECTION 02

Five things this was all built for

Cowork differs from a regular chat not in its interface, but in what it can do with its hands. Here are the five pillars.

2.1 File access

Claude reads and writes files in a folder on your computer. No more exported, dragged, waited, downloaded, put it back. You pick a folder, it works with it directly. That's the difference between a tool you visit and a colleague who sits inside your environment.

2.2 Clarifying questions

Any other AI guesses when the task is vague: it picks an interpretation, gets going, and hands back a polished answer to the wrong question. Cowork stops and builds a form with options and buttons. You answer in a couple of minutes and get an exact result.

2.3 Plugins

Without a plugin Cowork is a brilliant generalist, but without your industry vocabulary. Plugins fix that: one click, and it speaks the language of marketing, finance, or law.

2.4 Instructions

Cowork has no memory between sessions, every conversation starts from a blank slate. Instructions solve that: you write standing directions once, and they load at the start of every session. Global ones apply everywhere, folder ones kick in when you pick a specific folder.

2.5 Connectors

Link Claude to Slack, Google Drive, Notion, Figma, Asana, and fifty-odd other services. Once connected, it reads messages, digs into files, checks your calendar. Connectors are free on every plan.

Anthropic released 11 official plugins in January 2026

PLUGIN	WHAT IT'S FOR
Productivity	Tasks, calendars, daily workflows
Marketing	Content, campaigns, brand voice
Sales	Account research, call prep
Finance	Modeling, analysis, reporting
Data Analysis	SQL, dashboards, data exploration
Legal	Contract review, legal research
Product Mgmt	Specs, roadmaps, user stories
Customer Support	Ticket handling, reply drafts

Plugins are exactly what wiped \$285B off legal software stocks: Thomson Reuters dropped 16% in a single session.

SECTION 03

Forget prompts

ChatGPT trained you to write better, longer prompts. In Cowork the game is different: it's built on text files.

Take everything you know about your work: your writing style, your company rules, your best examples, past experience. Put it into text files, drop them in a folder, and show it to Claude. It's like an SOP for an employee. Only here the employee is Claude, and its SOP is your Claude Cowork folder.

KEY IDEA

The more quality context you give through files, the less you need to prompt. The result shifts from typical AI to it really sounds like something I would write myself. ChatGPT taught you to write better prompts, a skill that keeps depreciating. Cowork teaches you to give better context, and that compounds.

SECTION 04

Setup in 30 minutes

Open your calendar and block half an hour. Then go step by step.

00-05 MIN Install

Download the desktop app from claude.com/download (macOS or Windows). You need a paid plan: Pro at \$20/mo or Max from \$100. Open the app, switch to the Cowork tab at the top, and pick Opus 4.6 with Extended thinking, the smartest model.

05-10 MIN Context files

Create a Claude Cowork folder with four subfolders inside: ABOUT ME (1–2 files about you and your style), TEMPLATES (strong past work), PROJECTS (current projects with briefs), CLAUDE OUTPUTS (where finished results land).

10-15 MIN Global instructions

Settings → Cowork → Edit next to Global Instructions. Write the essentials: name and role, tone preferences, default formats, working style, and what to avoid.

15-20 MIN First task

Pick a folder and start a session: read all the files in this folder, then help me with a task, ask clarifying questions first. Choose something you already do well, so you can instantly tell whether the result is right.

20-25 MIN Plugin

Customize in the sidebar → Browse plugins. Good starting points: Productivity, Marketing, Sales. Type a slash in the chat to see the slash commands.

25-30 MIN Connector

Settings → Connectors. Connect the tool you use most: Slack, Google Drive, or Notion. Authorize it and ask Claude something about it. That is the moment it all clicks.

SECTION 05

One good file beats 50 uploads

Stop thinking about better prompts and start thinking about better files. Three of them handle almost everything.

about-me.md

Who you are and what you do. Three things: how you make money, how you like to communicate, and a piece of writing you are proud of.

brand-voice.md

How you sound. Your phrases, what reads as off to you, examples of strong texts, and the AI-writing patterns to avoid.

working-style.md

How you want Claude to work. Whether to ask questions first, short or long answers, which file formats you prefer.

TIP FROM RUBEN HASSID

Files work by compounding. Each week you refine them a little, and Claude gets better specifically at your work. Save them as .md, the format Claude reads best.

SECTION 06

Let Claude ask you

This is the feature that changes how you work, and almost no guide explains it properly.

Always add one simple thing to the end of your prompt:

PROMPT

Don't start yet. First ask me clarifying questions so we define the approach together. Only begin once we've agreed.

Cowork will build an interactive form with clickable options. You answer in a couple of minutes and get an exact result instead of fighting a text box.

MINDSET SHIFT

With a context window over a million tokens, you don't have to fear hallucinations on complex projects. Once Claude has read your files and pinned down the task with questions, the result stands firmly on real data.

SECTION 07

One prompt that kicks off everything

About 80% of Cowork sessions can start the same way. Here's the skeleton.

PROMPT

I want to [TASK] so that [SUCCESS CRITERION]. First study my CLAUDE COWORK folder. Then ask questions via AskUserQuestion. I want to refine the approach with you before you start.

Claude reads the context files and builds a form with questions about audience, goals, and preferences. You click through in a minute, it shows a plan, you approve, it executes and creates real files in the folder. If something goes sideways midway, you interrupt, it rebuilds the form and picks up where it left off.

MAC TIP

System Settings → Keyboard → Text Replacement. Add a shortcut (for example /prompt) and paste this template into it. Now typing /prompt drops it in automatically.

SECTION 08

Plugins: specialization in one click

Customize → Browse plugins (or claude.com/plugins) → Install. Then type a slash in the chat and watch the slash commands appear.

MARKETING

```
/marketing:draft-content Write a LinkedIn post about [topic]. Use the tone from brand-voice.md. Audience: [audience].
```

DATA ANALYSIS

```
/data:explore There's a CSV file in this folder. Summarize what's in it, flag anomalies, and suggest three analyses worth running.
```

LEGAL

```
Review the NDA in this folder. Flag anything unusual or one-sided.
```

Each plugin can be tuned to your company: Claude asks questions and remembers the answers.

SECTION 09

Claude inside your tools

Settings → Connectors. A catalog of 50+ integrations. Add, authorize, done. Set up once, and access is there in every session.

FREE EVERYWHERE

Connectors are available on every plan, including the free one. Connecting tools costs nothing, you only pay for Claude's actual work.

EXAMPLES

Summarize the key decisions from the #project-alpha Slack channel over the last two weeks.

Find my Slack messages from the past 7 days and gather everything that needs a reply.

Pull the Q1 numbers from the revenue file in Google Drive.

SECTION 10

What it looks like in real work

Four scenarios where Cowork saves hours. The context folder is already set up.

Content writing

The folder holds about-me.md, an anti-AI-cliché guide, and a couple of strong past texts.

PROMPT

I want to write my next newsletter about [topic]. First study the CLAUDE COWORK folder, then ask questions via AskUserQuestion. I want to refine the approach before you start.

Claude reads every file, asks about audience, tone, length, and angle, and builds an outline. You edit, it writes, and thanks to the voice profile the text actually sounds like you.

Consulting document

PROMPT

A client sent a brief for a 2026 AI adoption strategy, it's in /projects/client-x/. Read the brief, my deliverable template, and past examples. Make a first draft in .docx. Ask questions first.

It checks the brief against your template, sometimes asks about things you hadn't considered, and drops a finished .docx right into the folder.

Financial model

PROMPT

I want a spreadsheet modeling a potential exit from my social accounts. Start with AskUserQuestion to pin down the current numbers. Then build a spreadsheet in the style of Wall Street financial models.

Claude asks clarifying questions, builds an Excel with formulas, and finds and fixes its own mistakes while you're busy with something else.

Automatic Monday briefing

A special case: Cowork works without you. Set up a /weekly-briefings/ folder and use /schedule.

PROMPT

Every Monday at 7am, research [competitors] for news, product updates, and pricing changes. Save a summary to /weekly-briefings/ in markdown. Only events from the last 7 days.

As long as the computer is on and the app is open, it runs on its own. You wake up and the briefing is ready.

SECTION 11

Where Cowork still struggles

An honest look at the limits, so you know what to expect. This is a research preview, and it can make mistakes.

No memory between sessions

Every new session starts blank. Fixed with context .md files and global instructions.

Burns through limits fast

Reading files and building documents eats noticeably more than a regular chat. On Pro, keep an eye on Settings → Usage during heavy use.

Desktop only

No mobile version or sync. Keep your context files in a cloud folder (iCloud, Dropbox).

Stops when you close it

Close the app and the task halts. Don't close the window while it's working.

Doesn't make images

For photos and illustrations, use other services.

Agents sometimes miss

Cowork breaks a complex task into parts. About 10% of the time one agent goes off track, so check what it creates and don't send anything to a client unread.

SECTION 12

Your first 30 minutes

- ☐ Download the desktop app from claude.com/download
- ☐ Get Pro (\$20/mo) or Max (\$100/mo)
- ☐ Open Cowork (the tab up top between Chat and Code)
- ☐ Pick Opus 4.6 + Extended thinking
- ☐ Create a Claude Cowork folder with ABOUT ME, TEMPLATES, PROJECTS, CLAUDE OUTPUTS subfolders
- ☐ Write about-me.md: who you are, what you do, a sample of your work
- ☐ Write brand-voice.md: how you sound, examples, anti-patterns
- ☐ Write working-style.md: your format preferences
- ☐ Set up Global Instructions (Settings → Cowork)
- ☐ Run your first task with clarifying questions
- ☐ Install one plugin (Productivity is a good start)
- ☐ Connect one connector (Slack or Google Drive)

THE VALUE CURVE STARTS IMMEDIATELY

Setup takes about half an hour. But the payoff isn't someday later, it shows up with the very first task you used to do by hand.

STOP PROMPTING. START GIVING CONTEXT.



Based on material by Ruben Hassid (How to AI)
and Anthropic documentation · 2026

[CLAUDE.COM/DOWNLOAD](https://claude.com/download)

[CLAUDE.COM/PLUGINS](https://claude.com/plugins)